We just kept moving. Lismore, about 130 miles from Brisbane, is the place I associate more with my schooldays. You could say Lismore was the centre of the counter-culture in Australia, and it later became a Mecca for backpackers, a place where people seeking an alternative lifestyle came to roost. The second Aquarius Festival, the Aussie Woodstock, was held around Nimbin in 1973, and many people stayed on and set up co-operatives. My parents ran a puppet theatre. Over those years, there was a sense of fight-back against corporate agencies. Dairy farming was under threat from the big company Norco, and the Australian rainforest, famous at one time as the 'Big Scrub', was completely cleared in a way that left a scar on the land. My people cared about these things and I, in turn, came to care, too. School was at the local village of Goolmangar. I liked the idea of people, especially men, who could stand up for themselves and I was nurtured in this by a very excellent teacher called Mr King. In my view, even then, a lot of teachers were prissy, but this guy was strong in a way that seems important. He was this very competent individual and I felt safe with him. I think so much of my personality comes from what you might call congenital temperament, but experience plays its part, and I clung to the idea of manly competence as represented by this one good teacher. But, generally, I found school to be an agony of boredom. I wasn't the brightest person ever, but I was hungry for learning and facts, and the system just moved so slowly. I remember praying to God to make things move more quickly. I said, 'I don't think there's a God, but, if there is, I'll trade you two of my little fingers just to make this whole school thing go faster.'

At the same time I had this interest in generating children's lore, the kind of information, the kind of opinion, that passes for wisdom among the very young. I suppose I was good at it, creating believable factoids that worked their magic on my peers. I loved passing on my discoveries to them, like the time I maintained, quite convincingly, that rolling in the dirt was the perfect way to stop bleeding. I had this view that adults were the gods on earth, my mother the Supreme Being, but naturally I began to see that adults were fallible. Real life kind of begins at that point, when you see how adults in responsible positions are merely powerful and not necessarily in the right. It's the big lesson. I was able to see failures in compassion and sometimes I saw brutality. Australia was still quite provincial then, before the Internet, before cheap air travel, and you would be caned at school for misdemeanours. Going to so many schools, I was always trying to establish